

Guide 40 — Construction Laborer and Trade Helper

Controlled English working master — version 2.0

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What this job is

Construction laborers and trade helpers support the people, materials, tools, and work areas needed to build, repair, renovate, and maintain structures and infrastructure. Job titles can include construction laborer, construction worker, general laborer, construction helper, carpenter helper, electrician helper, plumber helper, masonry helper, roofer helper, or construction craft laborer.

This guide focuses on general construction labor and helper work. Helper experience does not automatically qualify a person to work independently in a regulated skilled trade or another specialist role. Requirements depend on the task, employer, project, and jurisdiction.

Construction can provide a practical entry point for people who prefer hands-on work and want to build experience while learning. The work can also be physically demanding and safety-critical. A short course, online badge, or generic safety card does not by itself authorize every task on every construction site.

What you may do

Typical responsibilities can include:

- cleaning and preparing work areas;
- loading, unloading, carrying, sorting, and staging materials;
- supplying tools or materials to skilled tradesworkers;
- helping set up approved temporary work areas when trained and assigned;
- digging, backfilling, compacting, or preparing small areas with permitted tools;
- mixing or moving construction materials when assigned;
- using employer-approved hand and power tools after training;
- helping measure, mark, protect, or organize work areas;
- assisting tradesworkers within the helper's authorized scope;
- maintaining housekeeping and waste-control standards; and
- reporting hazards, damaged tools, unsafe conditions, or instructions that exceed your training or authorization.

Exact duties vary by trade, project, employer, union agreement, jurisdiction, experience, and worksite.

Work environment

Construction laborers and helpers work on residential, commercial, industrial, civil, utility, road, renovation, and maintenance projects. Work may be indoors or outdoors and may involve heat, cold, rain, dust, noise, vibration, uneven surfaces, traffic, moving equipment, or changing site conditions.

BLS describes the work as physically demanding. Schedules can include early starts, nights, weekends, overtime, seasonal work, travel, or short-term assignment to different jobsites.

Physical requirements vary by job. Review the actual position's essential functions and safety requirements rather than assuming all construction laborer positions are the same.

Safety comes before speed

Construction work can expose workers to serious site hazards. This guide is for career preparation, not worksite instruction.

Always follow employer and site procedures, required orientation and task-specific training, PPE requirements, manufacturer instructions, access controls, and directions from authorized supervisors. Stop and ask when a task is unclear, unsafe, or outside your training.

OSHA's 10-hour and 30-hour Construction Outreach courses provide safety awareness, but OSHA states that Outreach training is voluntary, does not satisfy task-specific training requirements in OSHA standards, and is not a certification or license. Some employers, states, municipalities, unions, or project owners may still require an Outreach card.

Never use AI-generated instructions, social-media videos, or this guide as a substitute for required training, site procedures, or qualified supervision.

Skills that matter

Employers commonly value:

- reliability and punctuality;
- consistent safety habits;
- ability to listen and ask questions;
- teamwork and respectful communication;
- basic measurement and arithmetic;
- attention to surroundings and materials;
- safe tool habits after training;
- material organization and housekeeping;
- ability to follow written and verbal instructions; and
- willingness to learn from experienced workers.

A strong helper is not someone who takes unnecessary risks to appear fast. Safe work, attendance, learning, and accurate execution are better foundations for advancement.

Education and entry pathways

United States

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics groups **Construction Laborers and Helpers** as a major entry pathway. Formal education is not typically required, although some employers prefer a high school diploma or equivalent. Workers commonly learn on the job, and some construction laborers enter Registered Apprenticeship.

O*NET **47-2061.00 — Construction Laborers** is the principal detailed occupation for general laborer work. Craft-specific helper occupations are separate detailed occupations within the broader BLS group.

A practical U.S. entry sequence is to review local postings, identify the requirements employers repeatedly request, check public workforce and apprenticeship options before paying for private training, learn under appropriate supervision, and document only the skills you can actually perform safely.

Canada

Comparable work is classified under **NOC 75110 — Construction trades helpers and labourers**. Job Bank states that some helper jobs may require previous general-construction experience, some task categories may require specific certificates, and on-the-job training may be provided.

Canada does not have one universal qualification rule for every NOC 75110 position. Requirements can depend on the task, province or territory, employer, project, and whether the worker is entering a designated trade.

Construction Craft Worker is a Red Seal trade mapped to NOC 75110 and can be a progression route in participating provinces. That does not mean every generic construction-helper job requires Red Seal status.

Colombia

SENA is a primary free-first public training source. Its 2026 training offers include auxiliary, operator, technical, and technologist levels, with availability changing by cohort and region.

One current occupation-adjacent example is SENA's **Mampostería** operator program, listed as an in-person program of approximately **1,296 hours**. Its competencies include preparing construction materials, non-structural masonry, safety and health at work, environmental practices, and related site-support skills. Verify Betowa for live dates, location, entry requirements, and enrollment status; a program page does not guarantee an open place in your city.

SENA also maintains dedicated training for work at height. Treat that as a separate high-risk training area and verify current employer, site, and Colombian requirements rather than assuming a general construction course covers it.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Training and trade rules differ by country. OIT/Cinterfor's **Red institucional** is a useful route to public and national vocational-training institutions across Latin America and the Caribbean. Verify the actual course, cost, recognition, admissions, practical component, and enrollment status in your country.

Free-first learning strategy

Before paying for private training:

1. Review 15–20 current local job postings for the roles you want.
2. List the credentials and practical skills that appear repeatedly.
3. Check public workforce, apprenticeship, union, employer, SENA, or other national vocational options first.
4. Ask whether the training includes supervised practical work rather than only online theory.
5. Confirm whether local employers recognize the credential.
6. Get total tuition, fees, tool costs, PPE costs, refund terms, financing terms, and placement claims in writing.
7. Avoid borrowing for a course until you have confirmed that the credential is relevant to real jobs where you plan to work.

Free or low-cost introductory learning can help with terminology, measurements, safety awareness, tool identification, résumé preparation, and interview practice. It does not replace practical training where that is required.

Apprenticeship and work-based learning

United States

Apprenticeship.gov identifies Construction Laborers among construction-sector Registered Apprenticeship occupations. Registered Apprenticeship combines paid work, mentorship, related instruction, progressive skill development, and a portable credential.

Use the live Apprenticeship Finder to search by occupation and location. The presence of an occupation in the system does not guarantee an opening in every city or at every time.

Canada

Workers in NOC 75110 may use general labor/helper work as an entry point, while some pursue the Construction Craft Worker trade or another skilled-trade apprenticeship. Provincial and territorial authorities control local apprenticeship and certification rules.

Colombia and Latin America

Look for employer trainee roles, public vocational programs, contractor pathways, and supervised practice. In Colombia, SENA and the Agencia Pública de Empleo are useful starting

points. Elsewhere, use the relevant national training institution identified through OIT/Cinterfor.

Funding, grants, and employer support

United States

American Job Centers provide free employment assistance. CareerOneStop's WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder can help eligible job seekers identify programs that may qualify for Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act support. Eligibility and funding depend on the person, local workforce area, program, and provider; funding is not automatic.

Canada

Canada currently lists skilled-trades and apprenticeship supports including the **Canada Apprentice Loan**, with up to **CAD \$4,000** in interest-free loans for eligible apprentices, plus other programs under the Canadian Apprenticeship Strategy. Verify current eligibility and trade requirements before relying on funding.

Colombia and Latin America

Use public training systems before assuming private tuition is necessary. SENA's public training offers are free, but cohort availability and admission requirements vary. OIT/Cinterfor can help locate national vocational institutions elsewhere in the region.

Employer, union, and contractor support

Ask about paid onboarding, employer-paid safety training, PPE and tool policies, apprenticeship or trainee programs, tuition reimbursement, union training funds where applicable, supervised cross-training, and advancement from laborer/helper roles into a trade.

Obtain reimbursement conditions in writing before spending money. No employer benefit, apprenticeship seat, union access, promotion, or job offer is guaranteed.

Income and job outlook

United States — official data

BLS reports the following for the combined **Construction Laborers and Helpers** group:

- **May 2024 median annual wage:** 46,050***(\$22.14/hour)**;
- **Construction Laborers median:** \$46,730/year;
- **Helpers, Construction Trades median:** \$40,430/year;
- approximately **1,649,100 jobs in 2024**;
- projected employment growth of **7% from 2024 to 2034**; and
- about **149,400 projected openings each year**, on average, over the decade.

O*NET's current wage view for the detailed Construction Laborers occupation uses BLS 2025 wage data and reports a national median of about 47,120/year (**\$22.66/hour**). Keep the data years and occupation definitions separate when comparing figures.

These are national statistics, not promised starting wages. Pay varies by location, helper subtype, union coverage, project type, schedule, season, experience, and employer.

United States — supplementary private estimate

Salary.com reports an average U.S. **Construction Laborer/Helper** salary of about 43,578/year (**21/hour**) as of July 1, 2026, with a stated 25th–75th percentile range of about 40,504–**49,004**.

This is a private market estimate using its own title and methodology. It should not replace official BLS/O*NET data.

Canada — official data

Government of Canada Job Bank currently reports national wages for NOC 75110 of approximately:

- **CAD \$18.25/hour low;**
- **CAD \$25.00/hour median;** and
- **CAD \$40.00/hour high.**

The wage page says these figures were updated November 19, 2025 and use Statistics Canada Labour Force Survey data for the 2023–2024 reference period. Job Bank's 2025–2027 employment outlook ratings vary by province and region, so check the location you are considering.

Colombia and Latin America

Construction pay varies by country, city, project, skill level, and contract type. Use current public employment services and employer postings to establish local ranges. In Colombia, the SENA Agencia Pública de Empleo is a free public locator. Do not use one old vacancy as a national wage benchmark.

A practical 10-week starter plan

Weeks 1–2: Review local construction laborer/helper postings. Record recurring requirements such as shift, travel, physical demands, safety cards, driver's license, trade exposure, tools, and experience.

Weeks 3–4: Learn construction terminology, measurement basics, material handling, housekeeping, hazard awareness, and the difference between helper work and tasks requiring separate authorization.

Weeks 5–6: Compare public training, apprenticeship, employer trainee, union, community, or national vocational options. Prioritize programs with supervised practical learning and transparent costs.

Weeks 7–8: Prepare a simple skills record. List tools you have actually used, materials you know, jobsites you have worked on, safety training completed, attendance/reliability evidence, and tasks performed under supervision.

Weeks 9–10: Apply to roles that match your verified experience. Ask about onboarding, PPE/tools, safety training, work-based learning, schedule, travel, and who supervises new workers.

Building experience without already having the title

Transferable experience may come from warehouse/material handling, landscaping, maintenance support, manufacturing, farm work, moving/delivery, public works, or another construction-support role.

On a résumé, describe what you actually did. Useful evidence can include safe material handling, measuring, tool use, housekeeping, inventory/staging, attendance, teamwork, following work orders, and reporting hazards or defects.

Do not convert informal exposure into unsupported skilled-trade claims. Use titles and skill descriptions you can support.

Advancement

Possible next steps include senior construction laborer or lead hand, Construction Craft Worker where applicable, a skilled trade through its proper pathway, equipment operation after separate qualification, foreperson/site supervision after sufficient experience, or safety, materials, logistics, estimating, and project-support roles.

Before paying for advanced training, compare current postings for the exact next role you want and verify the credential employers request.

Accessibility and career fit

Physical demands are real, but construction work is not one identical job. Some positions involve more lifting, climbing, outdoor exposure, kneeling, or tool use than others. Evaluate the actual essential functions of a specific role and explore different construction-support roles, adaptive equipment, phased training, or applicable accommodation processes where appropriate.

This guide cannot determine whether a person is medically fit for a specific construction task and does not provide legal advice. Use qualified medical, vocational-rehabilitation, employer, union, or public-service guidance when needed.

Using AI responsibly in this work

AI tools can help with low-risk learning and administrative tasks such as explaining general construction terms, creating practice interview questions, organizing a study plan, helping rewrite a résumé bullet for work you actually performed, or summarizing public career information for you to verify.

AI should not replace site-specific safety instructions, manufacturer instructions, construction drawings or specifications, required professional decisions, task-specific controls, or qualified supervision.

If an AI answer conflicts with site procedure or an authorized supervisor, stop and verify through the employer's approved process.

Cybersecurity and privacy basics

Construction projects can contain commercially sensitive, personal, or security-sensitive information. Follow employer rules for passwords and multifactor authentication, shared devices, project systems, photos and videos, access information, customer and contractor records, incident reports, drawings and schedules, equipment-location data, and external AI services.

Do not upload protected project information, credentials, customer data, incident details, security arrangements, proprietary drawings, or other confidential material to an unapproved public AI system.

Avoid scams and weak training offers

Be cautious when a school, recruiter, or training seller:

- guarantees a job or a specific salary;
- claims one generic certificate authorizes all construction tasks;
- labels an OSHA Outreach card a professional certification or license;
- will not explain how much supervised practical training is included;
- pressures you to pay immediately;
- refuses to provide total cost, refund terms, tool/PPE charges, or financing terms in writing;
- cannot explain which employers recognize the training;
- asks you to pay for a job offer; or
- requests sensitive identity or banking information before you verify the organization.

Verify the provider independently. For expensive training, ask local employers, unions, apprenticeship sponsors, or workforce counselors what qualifications they actually recognize.

When to pause before spending money

Pause or delay enrollment when local employers do not request the credential, a public or employer-supported option may cover the same training, the provider cannot document supervised practical learning, total cost and refund terms are unclear, financing is difficult to justify against realistic local wages, the program promises guaranteed employment, or you have not verified the next step the training is supposed to unlock.

A useful training decision should connect to a real job pathway, not only to a certificate.

Sources and verification notes

Official sources should be checked again before making safety, training, licensing, funding, relocation, or employment decisions. Program offerings, wages, rules, and enrollment windows change.

United States

- BLS — Construction Laborers and Helpers: <https://www.bls.gov/ooh/construction-and-extraction/construction-laborers-and-helpers.htm>
- O*NET — Construction Laborers 47-2061.00: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/47-2061.00>
- O*NET — National wages, Construction Laborers: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/localwages/47-2061.00>
- OSHA — Construction standards: <https://www.osha.gov/laws-regs/regulations/standardnumber/1926/>
- OSHA — Outreach Training Program: <https://www.osha.gov/training/outreach/>
- Apprenticeship.gov — Construction: <https://www.apprenticeship.gov/apprenticeship-industries/construction>
- Apprenticeship.gov — Apprenticeship Finder: <https://www.apprenticeship.gov/apprenticeship-job-finder>
- CareerOneStop — American Job Centers: <https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/AmericanJobCenters/american-job-centers.aspx>
- CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder: <https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/EmploymentAndTraining/find-WIOA-training-programs.aspx>

Canada

- Statistics Canada — NOC 75110 context: <https://www23.statcan.gc.ca/imdb/p3VD.pl?CLV=1&CPV=7511&CST=01052021&CVD=1322706&D=1&Function=getVD&MLV=5&TVD=1322554>
- Job Bank — NOC 75110 requirements: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/8447/ca>
- Job Bank — NOC 75110 wages: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/wagereport/occupation/8449>
- Red Seal — Construction Craft Worker: <https://red-seal.ca/eng/trades/const-craft-work.shtml>
- Canada — skilled-trades/apprenticeship funding: <https://www.canada.ca/en/services/jobs/training/support-skilled-trades-apprentices/funding-opportunities.html>

Colombia and Latin America

- SENA — 2026 free training offer information: <https://www.sena.edu.co/es-co/Noticias/Paginas/noticia.aspx?IdNoticia=8975>
- SENA Betowa — Mampostería: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/mamposteria?modality=P&offertype=company&programId=219657>
- SENA — Trabajo seguro en alturas: <https://www.sena.edu.co/es-co/formacion/Paginas/trabajo-seguro-en-alturas.aspx>
- SENA — Agencia Pública de Empleo: <https://ape.sena.edu.co/Paginas/Inicio.aspx>
- OIT/Cinterfor — Red institucional: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/red-institucional>

Supplementary non-government compensation source

- Salary.com — Construction Laborer/Helper:
<https://www.salary.com/research/salary/opening/construction-laborer-helper-salary>

Important notice

This guide provides general educational and career-planning information. It does not guarantee employment, income, admission, funding, apprenticeship placement, licensing, certification, promotion, or any other result. Requirements vary by jurisdiction, employer, project, task, and time.

This guide is not a substitute for workplace safety training, qualified supervision, legal advice, medical advice, financial advice, licensing guidance, or instructions from an employer or regulatory authority.

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